

ANI

MADHYA PRADESH

AZAD FACTOR

By Rahul Noronha

Chandrashekhar Azad of the Bhim Army certainly understands the power of optics. On February 12, he organised a massive rally in Bhopal, which was attended by OBC, Dalit and tribal groups, and announced that his Azad Samaj Party (ASP) will contest all 230 seats in Madhya Pradesh and elect a chief minister and deputy CMs from marginalised groups if it won. The rally was held ostensibly as a show of strength against an anti-reservation meet organised by the Karni Sena Parivar in Bhopal in January, in which it had slammed the BJP for continuing with caste-based reservations.

With assembly polls in the state just months away, Azad wants to build a coalition of backward, SC and ST communities. In doing so, the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), which projects itself as the main voice of marginalised groups in the state, remains its key challenger. On the other hand, things have turned tricky for both Congress and the BJP. While the Karni Sena rally made the Congress happy, Azad's rally in Bhopal delighted the BJP as it threatened to pull away the Congress's traditional vote bank.

However, will Azad's entry really matter? His performance in the Uttar Pradesh polls did not match up to his media popularity. To have any bargaining power in MP, he'll have to win the support of both SCs and STs, who together account for 37 per cent of the state's population. "Organising a rally is one thing, contesting elections another," says state BSP chief Ramakant Pippal. Political analysts, too, aren't very excited. "Any leader from outside MP won't be able to impact the election unless he or she has been working in the state for a long time. Such shows of strength are meant to bargain with mainstream parties," says poll analyst Girija Shankar.

Azad's rally, thus, is a grand gesture, but whether it can spark any real shift depends on the groundwork the ASP manages to put in ahead of the polls. ■

KERALA

A LIFE MISSION GONE WRONG

By Jeemon Jacob

It was an unceremonious exit with no fanfare or mentions of his contributions to the service. M. Sivasankar, who was principal secretary to Kerala chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan during his first term, retired from service on January 31. On February 14, he was taken into custody by the Enforcement Directorate (ED)—his third arrest since the scam about alleged gold smuggling via diplomatic baggage broke in 2020. This time, it was over allegations that he had received kickbacks in one of the government's Life Mission scheme projects, where low-cost houses were to be built for the 2018 flood victims.

The arrest comes in the wake of new revelations by former UAE consulate worker Swapna Suresh, one of the prime accused in the gold smuggling case. Based on the interrogation of Sivasankar and Swapna's auditor Venugopal, ED sources say C.M. Raveendran, the current additional private secretary to the CM, will get a call next.

The case is built on allegations surrounding a Life Mission project in Wadakkanchery in Thrissur district for 140 low-cost houses with a Rs 18.5 crore grant from international agency Red Crescent Authority via the UAE consulate. The ED filed an affidavit in the Ernakulam district sessions court on February 19 alleging money laundering and saying Sivasankar was not cooperating. Incidentally, the ED case is based on an FIR by investigating agency Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) from back in 2019. The CBI's complaint then was that Red Crescent, a subsidiary of the International Red



PTI

WEST BENGAL

SMOKE RINGS IN SAGA

By Romita Datta

The impending byelection in the Sagardighi assembly seat in West Bengal's Murshidabad district on February 27 is the latest platform on which the ruling Trinamool Congress and the principal opposition party BJP are facing off, with no one losing the chance to treat it as a crystal ball through which to gaze at the 2024 general election. Subrata Saha of the TMC, whose death in December 2022 necessitated the bypoll, had won the seat with a margin of over 50,000 votes in the 2021 assembly election. But it can be a closer fight for the TMC this time around—its candidate Debashish Banerjee faces not just the BJP's Dilip Saha, but the Congress-appointed, Left-backed *beedi* magnate Byron Biswas, owner of Jeet Beedi Manufacturing Company, as 30 companies of central forces keep vigil. The results will be declared on March 2.

